

VICTORY CITY
By Salman Rushdie
PENGUIN HAMISH HAMILTON
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Salman Rushdie's new novel, *Victory City*, opens with a set piece of barely conceivable horror, as the preternaturally composed widows of a defeated army stride into the hissing flames of a giant bonfire. "Gravely, without making any complaint, they said farewell to one another and walked forward without flinching," recounts the narrator. "Nor were there any screams when their flesh caught fire and the stink of death filled the air."

It is—rendered in Rushdie's famously technicolour prose—the literary equivalent of a scene from a blockbuster like *Padmaavat*. For all the accolades bestowed on Rushdie, for all that he is one of the literary titans of our age, he remains at heart a mass entertainer, a writer with a distinctively *filmi* sensibility.

Rushdie, to borrow from the unnamed narrator of *Victory City*, is "a spinner of yarns...for the simple entertainment and possible edification of today's readers, the old and the young, the educated and the not so educated, those in search of wisdom and those amused by folly, northerners and southerners, followers of different gods and of no gods, the broad-minded and the narrow-minded, men and women and members of the genders beyond and in between, scions of the nobility and rank commoners, good people and rogues, charlatans and foreigners, humble sages, and egotistical fools." It is a thrilling, stirring sentiment. And even if you've heard it all before, even if a part of you knows it's Rushdie being Rushdie to the point of self-parody, a larger part of you can't resist standing up to applaud, to emit a wolf whistle or two, or maybe break into a dance in the aisles.

Victory City was written before Rushdie was stabbed onstage in New York State, causing life-altering injuries. That Rushdie is recovering and is able to tell the _New Yorker_ magazine that his "main overwhelming feeling is gratitude" is testament to his resilience, to his continuing defiance

Reading Rushdie, particularly now, in this later stage of his career, is a little like watching Shah Rukh Khan. What you're watching/ reading may be faintly ludicrous, a souffle of incident and spectacle that is lighter than air, but you cheer for Shah Rukh/ Rushdie nonetheless, you're filled with admiration and goodwill for him, for the fact that he's still around and doing his thing. Especially when the opposition to Shah Rukh/ Rushdie is so joyless, so filled with anger, so frankly stupid and literal.

This Valentine's Day just past marked the 34th year since the Ayatollah Khomeini declared his murderous fatwa. According to its diplomatic and political concerns, Iran has either tried to distance itself from or reiterate its support for the fatwa. But a call to murder a writer for writing once made can't be unmade. And so in August last year, a 24-year-old man with a knife sprinted onto a stage where Rushdie was speaking, at a pretty, pacific little festival in New York State attended largely by well-heeled retirees, and stabbed the author, causing life-altering injuries.

Victory City was written before the stabbing. That Rushdie is recovering and is able to tell the *New Yorker* magazine that his "main overwhelming feeling is gratitude" is testament to his resilience, to his continuing defiance. It's impossible to overstate the disgust any thinking person must feel for the fatwa—it is India's abiding shame that it banned imports of the book even before the fatwa—and so all the more remarkable that Rushdie has remained so uncorroded, so optimistic in the face of hate.

His latest novel is a fable set in the 14th century, charting the rise and fall (or victory and defeat) of Bisnaga, the southern Vijayanagara empire viewed through a magical realist scrim. The evidence of the glories of this empire, its experiments with religious and gender equality, its grappling with questions of control and freedom, are largely contained in the epic verses of a 247-year-old "blind poet, miracle worker and prophetess" named Pampa Kampana (modelled on the Sanskrit-language poet